The Deterioration of Egypt and the Arrival of Alexander the Great

When Ramesses II died, he was succeeded by Rameses III who continued with his policies. However, the incredibly wealthy country had caught the attention of their greedy neighbors. The mysterious Sea People had begun to raid the coastal towns of Egypt in hopes of becoming rich themselves. The origins of the Sea People are unknown just like the Hyksos but they are thought to have originated somewhere in south Aegean. Between 1,276 and 1,178 BCE, the Sea People attacked the Egyptian coastline viciously and relentlessly. Ramesses III arranged a great battle and defeated them at Xois in 1,178 BCE.

However, political strife had crept inside the government and his successors had to deal with serious internal problems. The people living in the conquered regions began to rebel against the pharaoh. After the reestablishment of the old gods, the priests of Amun had amassed so much land and money that they had the power to destabilize the entire government. Court officials had become so corrupt that during the reign of Ramesses XI (1,107 – 1,077 BCE), the government could not function anymore. It completely fell apart and resulted in the Third Intermediate Period.

The Kushite King Piye was able to reunite the divided kingdom under his rule, allowing the country to flourish once more. However, in 671 BCE, Esarhaddon of Assyria began making advancements into the country. By 667 BCE, he took control of the region through heavy warfare that left the country in ruin. This is what Cambyses II of Persia found when he attacked Pelusium in 525 BCE. The Egyptians had long worshipped cats because they were seen as symbols for the cat-headed goddess Bast. Cambyses II had men paint cats onto their shields along with other sacred images during battle. This helped the Persians in their fight against the deeply superstitious Egyptians who were forced to surrender. Egypt remained in Persian hands until Alexander the Great arrived in 332 BCE.